Lesson 20: The Summary-Response Essay: A Model on Stereotype Threat

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 2.1: Introduction; 2.2: Sample Student Summary/Response Essay: Stereotype Threat.

In this lesson

You will read a psychology textbook reading on stereotype threat and a student's summary-response essay about it, and study how the essay is organized: an introduction that summarizes the reading and ends with a thesis, three body paragraphs that each develop one part of the thesis, and a conclusion. Stereotype threat is a classic finding of social psychology, and Professor Paul Bloom discusses it in PSYC 110 (Lecture 17), so this lesson connects your English and psychology study. The model also shows the essay structure you will use for your own Unit 3 essay.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a summary-response essay is and how a U.S. academic essay is usually organized.
- Summarize the main findings of the reading on stereotype threat.
- Identify the thesis and the topic sentences of the model essay and show how they connect.
- Distinguish the summary from the response in the model essay.
- Write a short summary and response of your own.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
summary/response essay	an essay that explains an article or book and then shares your ideas about it	The sample essay is a summary/response essay.
stereotype	a fixed, oversimplified belief about what members of a group are like	women aren't as good at math
stereotype threat	the situation of a member of a stereotyped group who does an activity that can be judged, in a setting where the stereotype is relevant; it can lower performance	Black students did worse when told the test measured intelligence.
hypothesize	predict a result that research can test	He hypothesized that simply knowing about a stereotype could hinder performance.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
condition	one version of an experiment that one group of participants experiences	In one condition, participants were told ...
participants	the people who take part in a study	Black and White college students
naturalistic research	studies in real-life settings rather than in laboratories	Naturalistic research has confirmed that stereotype threats indeed have negative impacts.
generalize	apply results to other people or situations	... and thus, could not be generalized.
counterargument	an argument against the writer's position	The authors also address counterarguments and criticism.
credibility	the quality of being believed and trusted	... increases the credibility of their ideas
et al.	"and others": used for a source with several authors	McRaney et al.
according to / report / acknowledge	reporting language that introduces a source's ideas	According to research reported by McRaney et al., ...

Rules and explanations

What is a summary-response essay?

In a summary-response essay you **explain** an article or book you have read (summary) and **share your ideas** about it (response). The model essay summarizes "Stereotype Threat", a chapter from the textbook *The Psychology of Gender* by Kristy McRaney and her colleagues, and then evaluates how well the chapter explains its ideas.

The customs of a U.S. academic essay

The book explains that instructors and classmates expect a certain pattern, which may differ from newspaper writing and from academic writing in many other languages:

- several paragraphs of several sentences each;
- the main idea written clearly as a **strong thesis statement at the end of the first paragraph**;
- each body paragraph beginning with a **clear topic sentence**, not with evidence.

If readers do not find your ideas where they expect them, they may misunderstand your ideas or misjudge your writing skills. Knowing the structure also helps you follow other writers' ideas.

How the model essay is built

Part	What it contains
Introduction	A question to catch the reader's interest; a summary of the chapter (title, authors, definition, key findings); the thesis as the last sentence.

Part	What it contains
Body paragraphs 1-3	Each begins with a topic sentence that develops one part of the thesis, then gives evidence from the chapter (examples, quotations, paraphrases) and explains it.
Conclusion	Restates the thesis in new words, sums up the three points and ends with a final thought about why the topic matters.

Summary and response language

- **Summary** reports the authors' ideas objectively, with reporting language: *reported by, discuss, examine, according to, look at, acknowledge and respond to*.
- **Response** gives the writer's judgment (*understandable, compelling, balanced, credible*) with reasons and evidence. The writer may also use personal experience, as in body paragraph 3.
- Exact words go in quotation marks with a citation. Square brackets show words the writer changed or added to make a quotation clear: "Being aware that others believe [the stereotype] ..." (the reading says "it").
- The essay quotes a longer version of the chapter, so some of its quotations and paragraph numbers do not match the shortened reading in your lesson material.

> **Psychology note:** The reading uses APA style, the citation style of psychology: author and year, for example (Steele & Aronson, 1995). The student essay instead gives paragraph numbers, for example (McRaney et al. par. 5). In psychology papers, use APA style, and add a page or paragraph number for direct quotations.
>
> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Do not copy the source's sentences into a summary, even with small changes. Write the ideas in your own words, and when you need the author's exact words, use quotation marks and a citation, as the student writer does.

Practice

Exercise 1. Read and take notes (the book's "Try this!"). Read the reading "Stereotype Threat" in the lesson material. Take notes on how the authors explain the ideas and whether you are convinced by their points.

Exercise 2. Understanding the reading.

1. What three conditions create a stereotype threat?
2. In Steele and Aronson's 1995 study, what were participants told in the two conditions, and what happened?
3. What did Spencer, Steele and Quinn (1999) find about women and math?
4. Must people believe a stereotype for it to affect them?
5. At what age do children become aware of the stereotype that girls are worse at math?
6. How does Toni Schmader explain the effect of stereotype threat on test performance?
7. What was an early criticism of stereotype threat research, and what did later research show?

8. What can educators do to reduce stereotype threat? Give three things.

Exercise 3. Understanding the essay. Read the student essay in the lesson material.

1. How does the introduction begin, and why?
2. Which sentences of the introduction summarize the chapter? Find four phrases the writer uses to report the authors' ideas.
3. Copy the thesis. Where is it? Which three qualities of the chapter does it name?
4. Find the topic sentence of each body paragraph. Which part of the thesis does each one develop?
5. According to body paragraph 1, what three things make the chapter accessible?
6. According to body paragraph 2, what was the criticism, and how did researchers respond?
7. What personal experience does the writer describe in body paragraph 3, and how does it connect to the reading?
8. Which parts of the essay are mainly summary, and which are mainly response?

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my five-sentence summary of the reading 'Stereotype Threat': [paste]. Did I include all the key points? Did I copy any phrases from the original?"
- "Professor Bloom discusses stereotype threat in PSYC 110, Lecture 17. Ask me three questions that compare his explanation with the reading."
- "Play an early critic who doubts stereotype threat because the studies were done in labs. Argue with me for five turns. Then tell me which of my points were strongest."
- "Check my answers to Exercises 2 and 3 in the lesson material."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each |.

1. Did you know | that what others assume about you | can affect how well you perform on a test?
2. He hypothesized | that simply knowing about a stereotype | could hinder performance.
3. Not believing the stereotype, | but being aware that others believe it, | is enough to create a stereotype threat outcome.
4. Naturalistic research has confirmed | that stereotype threats indeed have negative impacts | on academic experiences, performance, and career goals.
5. Overall, | McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument | for the existence of stereotype threat.
6. Word stress: STER·e·o·type, hy·POTH·e·sis, nat·u·ral·IS·tic, cred·i·BIL·i·ty, par·TIC·i·pants.

Writing task

A short summary and response (250 to 350 words, two paragraphs) on the reading "Stereotype Threat". If you choose stereotype threat as the psychology topic for your Unit 3 essay, this

is your first draft of its introduction and first body paragraph.

1. **Summary paragraph:** begin with the title and the authors ("In 'Stereotype Threat,' a chapter in *The Psychology of Gender*, Kristy McRaney and her colleagues ..."). Give the definition and three or four key findings in your own words. Use at least three reporting verbs. End with a one-sentence thesis that states your response.
2. **Response paragraph:** begin with a topic sentence that develops one part of your thesis (for example: Are you convinced? Is the reading clear? Does it match your own experience or PSYC 110 Lecture 17?). Support it with evidence from the reading: a paraphrase or one short quotation in quotation marks. Explain how the evidence supports your point.

Self-editing checklist

- My first sentence names the title and the authors.
- My summary keeps the key points, uses my own words and adds no opinions.
- I used at least three reporting verbs (report, discuss, examine, argue, acknowledge ...).
- My thesis is the last sentence of the summary paragraph and states my response clearly.
- My response paragraph begins with a topic sentence, not with evidence.
- Any exact words from the reading are in quotation marks.
- I explained how each piece of evidence supports my point.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Professor Paul Bloom on stereotype threat and other effects of stereotypes (PSYC 110, Lecture 17, first half): https://oyc.yale.edu/psychology/psyc-110/lecture-17

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answer)

- Explanation: starts with a personal question (a job interview), defines the term, then describes studies in order (Steele and Aronson 1995; Spencer, Steele and Quinn 1999), a theory (Schmader), criticism, and solutions.
- Convincing? Yes, mostly: many studies, and naturalistic research answers the criticism. But the reading gives few numbers about how large the effect is.

Exercise 2

1. (1) The person is a member of the group being stereotyped, (2) the situation makes the stereotype relevant, and (3) the person is doing an activity that can be judged or evaluated.
2. Black and White college students took the GRE (a test for graduate admissions). Some were told it measured their intellectual capacities; others, that it was a problem-solving task not related to intellectual ability. When told it measured intelligence, Black participants were more aware of stereotypes, worried more about their ability and made excuses. Black students who were not reminded of negative stereotypes did much better.
3. They gave students a GRE math test. Some were told that gender differences had been found on the test; others were told there was no gender difference. When women experienced stereotype threat, their test scores were lower.
4. No. Being aware that others believe the stereotype is enough.
5. Around ages 7 to 8.
6. Worry about the stereotype distracts the person's attention from the test, so she cannot fully focus, and her performance drops.
7. Most studies were done in labs, not natural settings, so critics said the results could not be generalized (Paul Sackett expected only a small effect in natural settings). Naturalistic research later confirmed negative effects on academic experiences, performance and career goals.
8. Not presenting tests as measures of ability; making sure classrooms do not show the accomplishments of only certain groups; teaching students about stereotype threat.

Exercise 3

1. With a question to the reader: "Did you know that what others assume about you can affect how well you perform on a test?" It catches the reader's interest and introduces the chapter's main finding.
2. Sentences 2 to 6 (from "This is just one of the findings ..." to "... responds to criticism of the idea of stereotype threat"). Phrases: "reported by", "discuss", "According to research reported by", "also look at", "acknowledges and responds to".
3. "Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat; the information they present is engaging, seems balanced, and helped me make sense of my own experiences." It is the last sentence of the introduction. Qualities:

engaging (and understandable), balanced, and personally meaningful (it helped the writer understand her own experiences).

4. In each body paragraph, the topic sentence is the first sentence.
    - Body 1: "While McRaney and her colleagues draw on many academic studies, they still manage to present the information in a way that is both interesting and understandable ..." (engaging)
    - Body 2: "The authors also address counterarguments and criticism of the research they present, which makes them seem balanced ..." (balanced)
    - Body 3: "Finally, in reading the chapter, I realized that stereotype threat has had an impact on me personally." (helped me make sense of my own experiences)
5. Personal questions at the start; a conversational tone with the second person ("you"); paraphrases and summaries of studies instead of direct quotations.
6. The studies were conducted in labs, not natural settings, so they could not be generalized. More naturalistic research was conducted, and it confirmed the earlier lab-based studies.
7. In her mostly male freshman math class in high school, she did not ask questions because she did not want others to think she was bad at math, and her test results suffered. The reading says that worry about confirming a stereotype can make it harder for women to receive and use helpful feedback, and can make students avoid class discussions.
8. Mainly summary: the introduction (except the first and last sentences). Mainly response: the thesis, the three body paragraphs and the conclusion, although the body paragraphs use summaries and quotations from the chapter as evidence.

My notes